TALK TWO

2 The One They Were Waiting For

"But we trusted that it had been he which should have redeemed Israel."

LUKE 24:21

When priests came from Jerusalem to question John the Baptist, they already had several possibilities in mind. "Who art thou?" they asked. John told them, "I am not the Christ." They tried again: "Art thou Elias?" He said no. "Art thou that prophet?" Again, no. They were expecting someone, and a man baptizing crowds in the Jordan River had caught their attention. They knew the promises well enough to ask questions. But when Jesus came, many people struggled to recognize Him. How could they have waited so long and still missed Him?

Think about life for the people who were waiting. Rome ruled their country. There were occupying Roman soldiers, taxes collected for Rome, and rulers who held power only by Rome's permission. No king from David's family line had ruled for hundreds of years. When people read the promises about a deliverer, they had reasons to hope that meant freedom from Rome. But before Jesus was born, the angel told Joseph, "thou shalt call his name Jesus: for he shall save his people from their sins." The Father had sent His Son to overcome sin and death. People could see what Roman rule was costing them every day. It was harder to see how much more they needed the rescue Jesus came to offer.

Moses had given them one way to think about the promised deliverer. He had led Israel out of Egypt, and before he died he told the people, "The Lord thy God will raise up unto thee a Prophet from the midst of thee, of thy brethren, like unto me; unto him ye shall hearken." That promise was behind the priests' question to John: "Art thou that prophet?" They were looking for someone like Moses. Moses had freed their ancestors from a foreign ruler, so they might expect the next deliverer to do the same. Jesus spoke of His relationship to Moses: "Think not that I am come to destroy the

law, or the prophets: I have come not to destroy, but to fulfil." He had come to complete the work Moses had pointed toward, though that would involve more than the people expected.

Promises about David's family also gave them hope for a king. Isaiah describes a ruler coming from the family of Jesse, David's father. He says that "with righteousness shall he judge the poor" and describes a world where the wolf and the lamb live together and nothing hurts or destroys in God's holy mountain. Imagine hearing that while living under Roman rule. A righteous king and a world at peace would sound like the answer to your prayers. Those promises were true, but there were other promises about Him.

In another chapter, God says, "Behold my servant, whom I uphold." This servant does not shout in the streets. Later, Isaiah describes this servant as someone "despised and rejected of men; a man of sorrows," who is wounded for our transgressions and brought like a lamb to the slaughter. It is harder to see how that person fits with the king the Jews were expecting. How could the promised deliverer be rejected and killed? All of these passages were about Jesus, but understanding how they belonged together was difficult.

Some men tried to be the king the people wanted. The Jewish historian Josephus describes men who claimed kingship after Herod died. One was a shepherd named Athronges, who put a crown on his head and led his brothers in fighting. Another was Simon, who had been one of Herod's slaves and also put a crown on his head. The book of Acts also records Gamaliel speaking about failed leaders and their followers. Theudas was killed, and those who followed him scattered. Judas of Galilee died, and his followers dispersed too. People had seen men gather a following and promise change, only for it to end in violence and disappointment. This was the world in which Jesus began teaching.

Some of the people following Jesus expected Him to take political power too. After He fed five thousand people with a few loaves, John says Jesus saw that they would "come and take him by force, to make him a king." He went up a mountain alone. They had seen what He could do, and they wanted Him as their king, but He did not let them dictate what His mission would be. Even

among the Twelve was a man Luke calls "Simon called Zelotes," Simon the Zealot, from the party that wanted Rome out by force. Jesus brought together people with different backgrounds and expectations, and they had to learn what it meant to follow Him. He was not gathering an army to fight Rome.

Jesus challenged their understanding of the Messiah when He asked the Pharisees, "What think ye of Christ? whose son is he?" They answered, "The son of David." That answer came from scripture, but Jesus asked them to consider another passage. If the Messiah was David's son, why did David call Him "Lord" in the psalm? No one answered Him. They knew whose family the Messiah would come from. His question pointed beyond that family line. Being David's descendant did not explain every important thing about Him.

Later, standing before the Roman governor, Jesus said, "My kingdom is not of this world: if my kingdom were of this world, then would my servants fight." He was about to be put to death, and He still was not calling His followers to fight for power. If He had defeated Rome and stopped there, the people would still have needed forgiveness. They would still have faced death. His work had to reach those things too. The promises of a peaceful kingdom would be fulfilled, but first He would suffer for the people He had come to save.

Even His disciples struggled to understand this after His death. Two were walking to a village when a stranger joined them and asked what they were discussing. They told Him about Jesus and said, "But we trusted that it had been he which should have redeemed Israel." You can hear the disappointment in that sentence. They had believed He was the one, and now He had been crucified. They did not yet understand how His death could be part of redeeming Israel. The stranger walking beside them was Jesus, and He answered, "O fools, and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken." The word "all" matters here. They had believed the promise of a redemption from Rome, but they also needed to believe what the angel had said about saving them from their sins.

Some promises are easier to hold on to than others. We welcome the ones about peace and help, but we may struggle with what the Lord asks us to endure or change. We can pray for help with a clear idea of what the answer

should look like. If something different happens, we don't know what to make of it. These disciples were talking to the risen Lord about how He had disappointed their hopes. Can you imagine? But we are pretty slow of heart too, and there is more happening than we understand in the moment.

At the beginning, the priests asked John whether he was the Christ, Elias, or the prophet foretold by Moses. The next day, John saw Jesus coming toward him and called Him a name the priests had not mentioned: "Behold the Lamb of God," John said, "which taketh away the sin of the world." This name helps me understand what the Messiah came to do, and why I need Him too.

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The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.